

124

Jesus of Nazareth

The Word made flesh, who lived among us, died for sinners, rose again, and reigns as Lord.

Jesus of Nazareth stands at the centre of the whole Bible, which looks forward to him, back to him, and ahead to his return. Born to Mary in Bethlehem and raised in Nazareth, at about thirty he began to preach that the kingdom of God was at hand. For a few short years he taught, healed, welcomed outsiders, forgave sins and trained twelve disciples. Pontius Pilate had him crucified in Jerusalem. On the third day he rose, and after forty days he ascended. Christians confess him as fully God and fully human, the Saviour of the world.

At a glance

Name	Greek <i>Iesous</i> , Hebrew <i>Yeshua</i> , "the Lord saves" (Matt 1:21)
Titles	Christ ("anointed one"), Son of God, Son of man, Lord, Emmanuel
Family	Son of Mary; legal son of Joseph; of David's line (Matthew 1:1)
When	Born c. 6–4 BC; crucified c. AD 30 (some prefer AD 33)
Key places	Bethlehem, Nazareth, Capernaum and Galilee, Jerusalem
Key people	John the Baptist, the Twelve, Mary Magdalene, Caiaphas, Pontius Pilate
Main passages	Matthew, Mark, Luke and John; Acts 1:1–11

"And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth."

John 1:14, KJV

The life of Jesus of Nazareth

Dates approximate. John mentions at least three Passovers, so many think the ministry lasted about three years.

c. 6–4 BC <i>Bethlehem</i>	● Born of Mary Conceived by the Holy Ghost, he is laid in a manger; shepherds and wise men come to worship. <i>Matthew 1:18–2:12; Luke 2:1–38</i>
Age 12	● In the temple He stays behind, asking the teachers questions, about his Father's business. <i>Luke 2:41–52</i>
c. AD 28–29 <i>About 30</i>	● Baptized and tempted John baptizes him; then he answers the devil's temptations with Scripture. <i>Matthew 3:13–4:11; Luke 3:21–23</i>
Early ministry	● Galilee He preaches that the kingdom is at hand, calls fishermen, and heals many. <i>John 2:1–11; Mark 1:14–39</i>
The busy years	● Crowds and conflict He chooses twelve, teaches in parables and eats with sinners; leaders plot against him. <i>Mark 3:1–19; 6:30–44; Luke 15:1–2</i>
Caesarea Philippi	● Confession and glory Peter confesses him as the Christ; days later he is transfigured. <i>Matthew 16:13–17:9</i>
c. AD 30 or 33 <i>Passover week</i>	● The cross After the Last Supper and Gethsemane, he is tried, crucified and buried. <i>Matthew 21:1–27:66; John 18–19</i>
The third day to the fortieth	● Risen and ascended He appears to Mary Magdalene, the apostles and five hundred, then ascends. <i>Luke 24; John 20–21; Acts 1:3–12; 1 Corinthians 15:3–8</i>

Key activities

The Gospels are four portraits, not a diary, and sometimes order events differently. These are grouped by theme.

-
- I Proclaimed the kingdom.** "The kingdom of God is at hand: repent ye, and believe the gospel." *Mark 1:14-15*

 - 2 Called disciples.** He called fishermen and a tax collector, and chose twelve to be sent out. *Mark 1:16-20; 2:14; 3:13-19*

 - 3 Taught with authority.** He taught love for enemies, secret prayer and trust in the Father. *Matthew 5-7*

 - 4 Told parables.** The sower, the good Samaritan and the lost son show what God's kingdom is like. *Matthew 13:1-23; Luke 10:25-37; 15:11-32*

 - 5 Healed and showed his power.** He healed the sick, cast out demons, calmed a storm and fed five thousand. *Mark 1:32-34; 4:35-41; John 6:1-14*

 - 6 Forgave sins.** He forgave a paralysed man, then healed him to show his authority. *Mark 2:1-12*

 - 7 Welcomed outsiders.** He came "to seek and to save that which was lost." *Luke 15:1-2; John 4:7-26; Luke 19:1-10*

 - 8 Raised the dead.** "I am the resurrection, and the life." *Mark 5:35-43; John 11:25, 38-44*

 - 9 Served his disciples.** He washed their feet and gave them the bread and the cup. *John 13:1-17; Luke 22:14-20*

 - 10 Surrendered in prayer.** "nevertheless not my will, but thine, be done." *Luke 22:39-46*

 - 11 Gave his life.** "Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do." *Luke 23:33-46; John 19:28-30*

 - 12 Sent his followers.** "Lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world." *Matthew 28:18-20*

Across Scripture

Key passages only (Luke 24:27). 25 December and the holy sites are later tradition.

Old Testament

Genesis 3:15	The woman's seed; many call it the first gospel promise
Genesis 12:3; 2 Samuel 7:12–16	"The son of David, the son of Abraham"
Isaiah 9:6–7; 53; Micah 5:2	The child, the wounded servant, the Bethlehem ruler
Psalms 22:1; 110:1	Quoted by Jesus on the cross and of David's Lord
Daniel 7:13–14	One "like the Son of man" receives the kingdom
Echo: 1 Corinthians 15:45; 5:7	The last Adam and our Passover

New Testament

Matthew – John; Acts 1:1–11	His life, death, rising and ascension
John 1:1–14; Philippians 2:5–11	The Word made flesh, in "the form of a servant"
1 Corinthians 15:3–8	Died, buried, rose, appeared: an early summary
Revelation 22:20	"Even so, come, Lord Jesus"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Peter answer, "But whom say ye that I am?" (Matthew 16:15–16)?
2. *Understand:* How does Mark 10:45 sum up Jesus' life?
3. *Apply:* Jesus welcomed people others avoided. Who could you welcome this week?
4. *Apply:* How would you answer "whom say ye that I am?" today, and how will it shape your week?